

THE PUP ROUTINE

The First 8 Weeks Puppy System

The calm, checkable routine for your puppy's first two months at home — potty, crate, sleep, socialization and vet visits, laid out so you always know what today is for.

A free system from thepuproutine.com · keep it printed on the fridge

How this system works

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Puppies don't need a perfect owner. They need a **consistent** one. This guide gives you five small systems that run your first eight weeks: a daily routine, a potty schedule, a crate plan, a sleep rhythm, and a socialization checklist. Print it, put it where the household sees it, and let the routine do the thinking while you enjoy the puppy.

- **Follow the routine, not your mood.** Dogs learn from repetition; the schedule is the trainer.
- **One rule per moment.** Each section below is a checkable action, not theory.
- **Everyone in the house runs the same system.** Inconsistency is the #1 reason training stalls.

This guide describes widely used training and husbandry conventions (positive-reinforcement methods, AAHA-style vaccination timing). It is not veterinary advice — confirm health decisions, vaccine timing and anything about your specific puppy with your own vet.

The week-by-week focus (age ~8–16 weeks)

Week home	Main focus	Win of the week
1	Settling in · potty rhythm · crate = good place	Puppy naps in crate with door open
2	Potty schedule tightens · name response · handling (paws, ears, mouth)	First full day without an indoor accident
3	Crate door closed for naps · short alone-time reps (1–5 min)	Calm 5 minutes alone
4	Socialization push (see checklist) · sit & recall foundations	10 new experiences logged
5	Leash intro in quiet places · impulse-control games	Loose-leash 20 meters
6	Alone-time stretches (15–30 min) · settle-on-mat	Relaxed 30 minutes alone
7	Generalize: new places, surfaces, sounds · recall outdoors on long line	Recall past a mild distraction
8	Consolidate. Keep every system running; raise difficulty slowly	The routine feels boring — that's success

System 1 — The daily routine

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Young puppies thrive on a predictable loop: **sleep** → **potty** → **food/water** → **play/train** → **potty** → **sleep**. Repeat that loop all day and most "behavior problems" never appear.

Time	Block	Notes
07:00	Wake + potty (carry out if needed)	Out the same door, same spot, every time
07:15	Breakfast + water	Potty again 10–20 min after eating
07:45	Play / 3-minute training rep	Short. End before the puppy tires
08:30	Crate nap (60–120 min)	Puppies need 18–20 h sleep/day
10:30	Potty → play/socialization outing	One new experience per day is plenty
12:00	Lunch → potty → nap	Same loop
15:00	Potty → enrichment (sniffing, chew, puzzle)	Mental work tires more than running
17:30	Dinner → potty → family time	Calm presence, handling practice
19:30	Last play + short training rep	Wind down after this
21:30	Final potty → crate for the night	Boring, calm, lights out

Adjust the clock, keep the loop. Your hours can differ — what matters is the same order of blocks every day, and a potty break after every sleep, meal, drink and play burst.

System 2 — Potty training

The three rules

1. **Out after every trigger:** waking, eating, drinking, play, excitement — and at least every hour at 8–10 weeks (a common rule of thumb: hold time in hours $\approx$ age in months + 1, awake).
2. **Boring trips, big parties.** Go out on leash, stand still, say nothing. The moment the puppy goes: praise + a treat *on the spot outside*, never after coming back in.
3. **Interrupt, never punish.** Catch an accident mid-act: calm "ah-ah", scoop up, finish outside, party. Found it later? Clean it (enzymatic cleaner) and say nothing — punishment after the fact only teaches hiding.

Accidents are data. Every accident = the schedule was too loose or supervision slipped. Tighten the interval for two days, then widen again.

System 3 — Crate training

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The crate is a bedroom, not a punishment. Build value in steps and never move two steps at once.

Step	What you do	Move on when...
1	Crate open, meals + treats scattered inside	Puppy walks in freely
2	Feed in crate, close door during the meal, open after	Relaxed through the meal
3	Door closed for naps while you're in the room	Falls asleep without fuss
4	You leave the room for 1–5 min during a nap	Stays settled
5	Stretch alone-time: 15 → 30 → 60 min, random order	Calm at 60 min

- Crate size: stand up, turn around, lie flat — not bigger during potty training.
- Whining test: pause at the door — a settling puppy quiets in ~2 min; frantic escalation means you moved too fast, go back one step.
- Night: crate near your bed the first weeks; one silent night potty trip at 8–10 weeks is normal.

System 4 — Sleep

Puppies need **18–20 hours of sleep per day**. An overtired puppy looks like a "bad" puppy: biting, zoomies, ignoring everything. When behavior falls apart, the answer is almost always a nap.

- Rhythm: roughly **1 hour awake** → **1–2 hours asleep**, all day, at 8–12 weeks.
- Protect naps like appointments — family rule: sleeping puppy is invisible.
- Evening "witching hour" biting = overtiredness. Calm chew in the crate, lights low.

System 5 — Socialization checklist

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Roughly before the 14–16 week mark, puppies file new experiences as "normal". After it, new things default to "suspicious". This window is the highest-leverage work of the entire first year: **one new thing a day, always paired with treats, always at the puppy's pace.**

Before the vaccine series is complete, socialize **smart**: carry the puppy in public, use the car as a viewing platform, visit vaccinated friendly dogs at home — avoid ground contact in high-dog-traffic areas. Behavior professionals broadly agree the socialization window matters too much to wait out entirely; agree on the line with your vet.

People & handling

- ☐ Men with beards/hats · children · elderly
- ☐ Bikes, joggers, strollers passing
- ☐ Paws, ears, mouth, tail handled daily
- ☐ Collar grab → treat (10× per week)
- ☐ Brush, towel rub, nail clipper shown
- ☐ Being picked up calmly

Dogs & animals

- ☐ Calm adult dog (vaccinated, known)
- ☐ Watching dogs play from a distance
- ☐ Cats / livestock seen calmly

Places & surfaces

- ☐ Car rides (short, ending somewhere fun)
- ☐ Pavement, grass, gravel, metal grate, wet ground
- ☐ Stairs (few steps), elevator, automatic doors
- ☐ Quiet street → busier street progression
- ☐ Vet practice happy-visit (scale + treats, no needle)

Sounds & sights

- ☐ Vacuum, doorbell, washing machine
- ☐ Traffic, thunder/fireworks audio at LOW volume
- ☐ Umbrellas, hi-vis vests, wheelchairs, skateboards

Vet & vaccine timeline (standard convention — confirm locally)

Age	Standard step
6–8 weeks	First core combination vaccine (distemper/parvo series) · deworming · vet intake check
10–12 weeks	Second core vaccine · discuss microchip registration, parasite prevention
14–16 weeks	Final core vaccine of the puppy series · rabies where required by local law
~6 months	Discuss neutering timing with your vet (breed- and size-dependent)

Timing follows widely used veterinary guidelines (e.g. AAHA canine vaccination guidance); exact schedule, products and local legal requirements are your vet's call.

The daily tracker (print one per day)

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Time	Potty (✓/accident)	Meals	Nap start–end	Training / new experience
Morning				
Midday				
Afternoon				
Evening				
Night				

Week review (Sunday, 5 minutes)

- ☐ Accidents this week vs last week — fewer?
- ☐ Longest calm alone-time this week: _____ min
- ☐ New experiences logged: _____ / 7
- ☐ Is everyone in the house running the same rules?
- ☐ Next week's single focus: _____

What happens after week 8? The systems stay, the difficulty rises: adolescence, recall around distractions, enrichment routines, alone-time for real workdays. That's what the weekly Pup Routine email walks you through — one system per week, no fluff. **thepuproutine.com**